



PARLIAMENT OF SIERRA LEONE
Cybersecurity Unit

CYBERSECURITY AWARENESS MONTH 2026

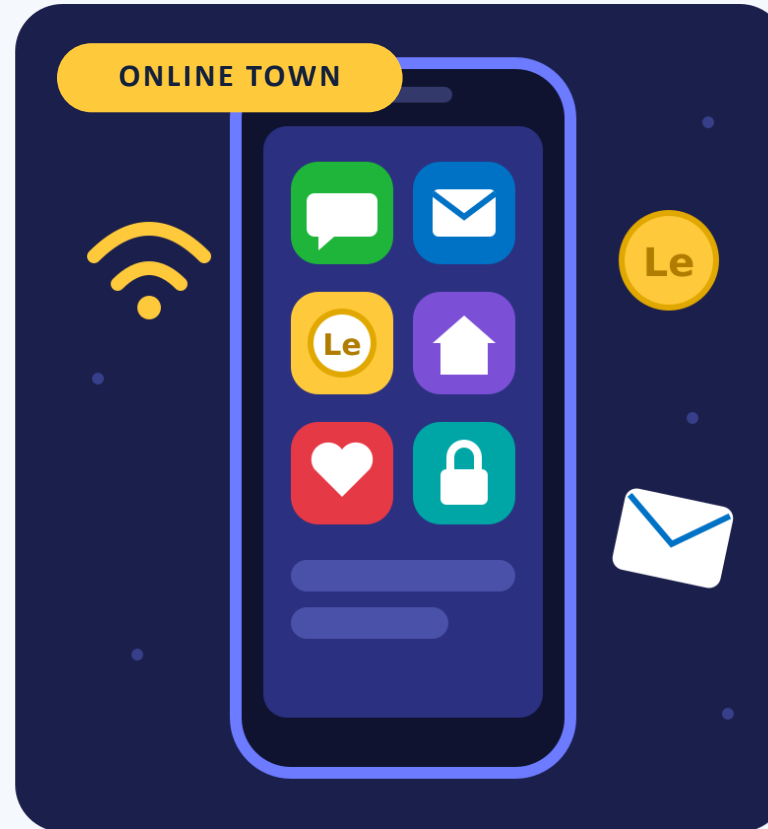
The Cyber Law, Explained for Kids

Sierra Leone's Cyber Security and Crime Act, 2021 — all 58 sections, made simple

Securing Sierra Leone's Digital Future: A National Call to Cyber Resilience
Partnership. Protection. Progress.



Two towns, one set of good rules



In the real town... → **online**



Houses
→ **Your accounts**



Letters
→ **Your messages**



Money
→ **Mobile money & bank apps**



Police & firefighters
→ **Cyber helpers**



Both towns need rules to keep everyone safe, and helpers to make sure the rules are followed!

In 2021, Parliament made a law for the online town



June 2021

Parliament passes the law



November 2021

The President signs it



Today

It protects everyone in Sierra Leone

58

sections

Like 58 short rules

7

parts

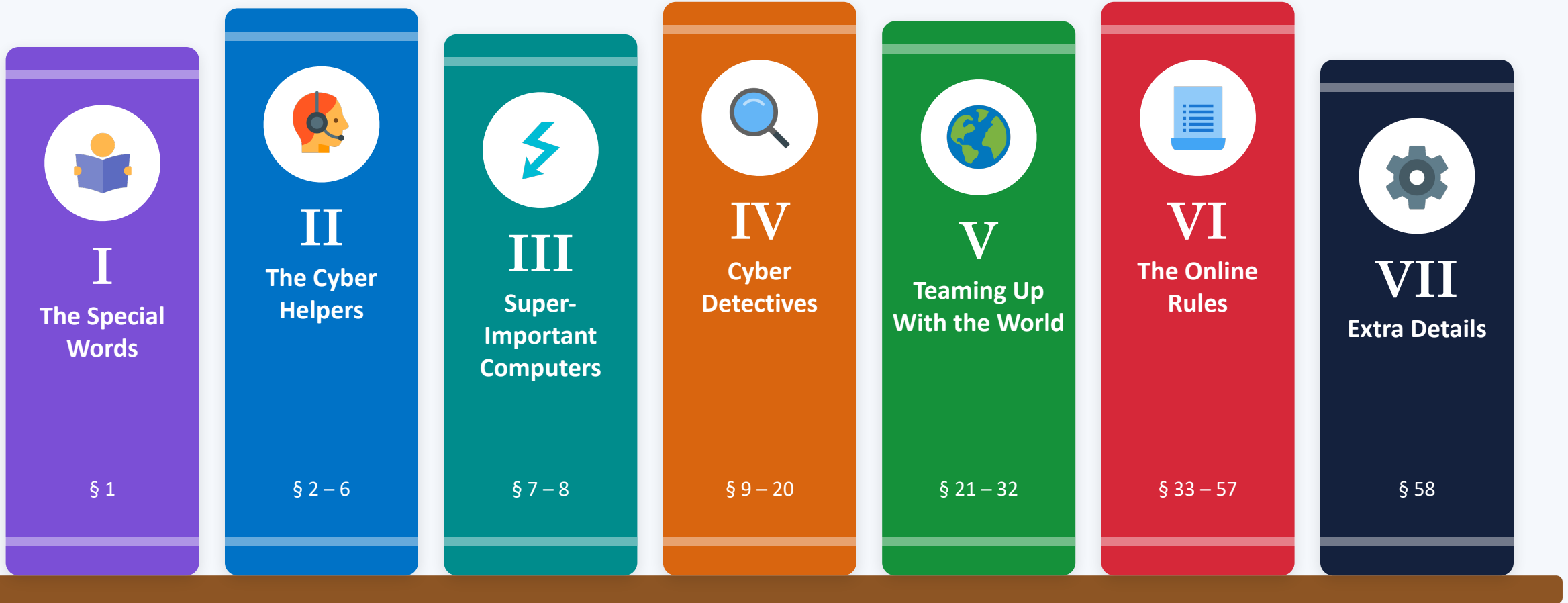
Like 7 chapters in a book

1

big goal

A safe online Sierra Leone

The law is like a book with 7 chapters



PART I

The Special Words

Section 1



Before a football match, everyone agrees what a "goal" means. Let's learn the law's special words!

The law's special words



Computer system

Any device that thinks: phone, laptop, tablet. Your phone counts!



Data

Information inside a device: photos, messages, apps.



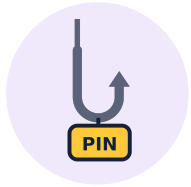
Password

The secret key that opens your account or device.



Unauthorised

Going where you have no permission to go.



Phishing

A trick to make you give away your password or PIN.



Identity theft

Stealing someone's details and pretending to be them.



Cyberstalking

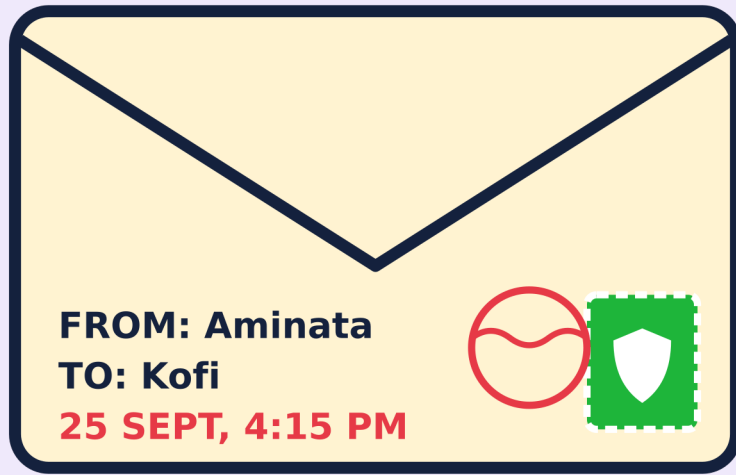
Following or messaging someone again and again to scare them.



False news

Made-up stories dressed up to look like real news.

Envelope or letter? Two kinds of information



VS



TRAFFIC DATA

Information ABOUT a message: who sent it, to whom, when and how long. Like the outside of an envelope.

CONTENT DATA

What the message actually SAYS. Like the letter inside the envelope.

PART II

The Cyber Helpers

Sections 2 – 6



Every town needs safety helpers. Meet Sierra Leone's cyber team!

A fire station for the internet



(Real name: the National Computer Security Incidence Response Coordination Centre!)



The Cyber Chief

National Cyber Security Coordinator

10+ years

of cyber experience

5 years

per term (max. 2)

Chosen

by the President, approved by Parliament

What the Centre does (Section 3)



**Protects
computers**



**Makes the
national cyber
plan**



**Runs detective
labs**



**Helps judges &
police**



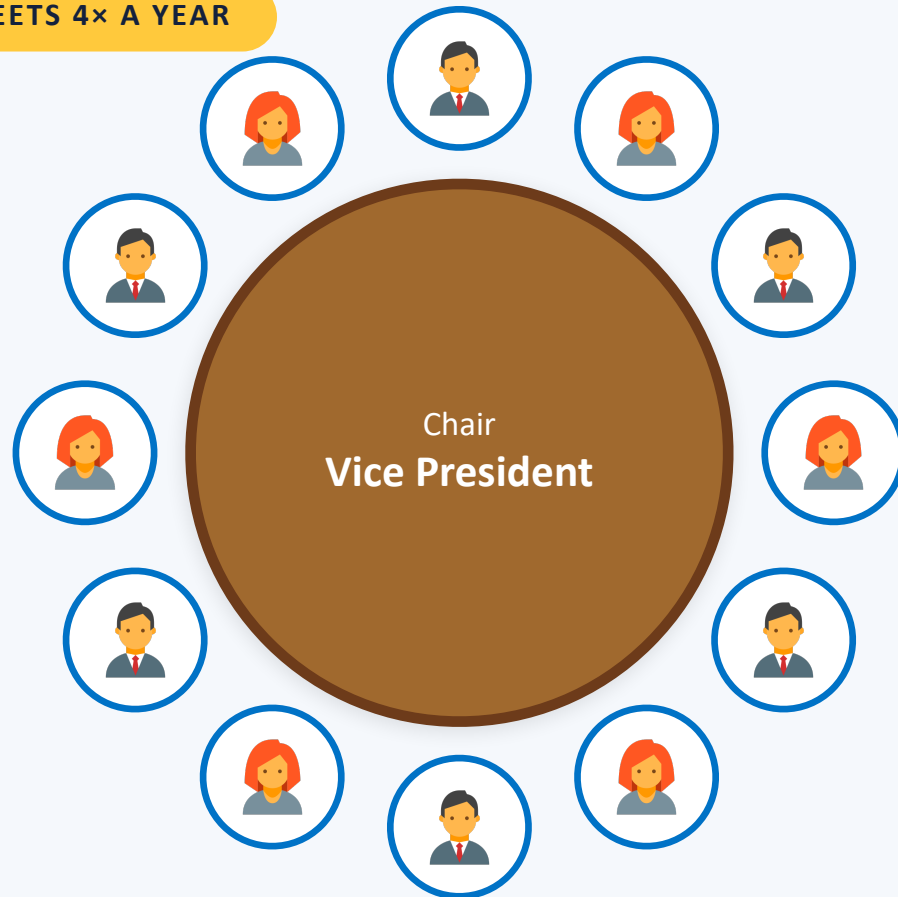
**Works with
the world**



When something goes wrong online, this team rushes to help, just like firefighters!

The Cyber Council: the country's top leaders

MEETS 4× A YEAR



Who sits at the table?

5 Government Ministers

Police chief

Army chief

Security & intelligence chiefs

Telecoms Commission head

Bank of Sierra Leone Governor

Financial Intelligence Unit

A senior lawyer

The Cyber Chief (secretary)

What the Council does (Section 5)



Guides the plan



Advises the
Government



Matches world
rules



Promotes cyber
education

The Cyber Safety Fund: a money box for safety

Money comes from...



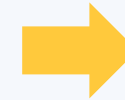
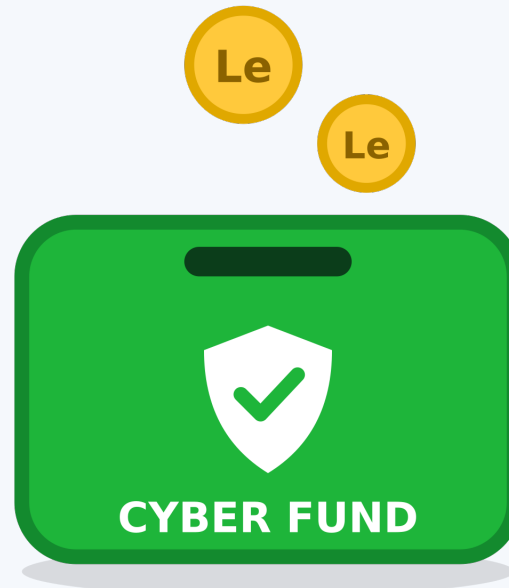
The Government



Gifts



World partners



up to
30%

can pay for
teaching people
like YOU about
cyber safety!



Every coin is checked. The Auditor General checks the Fund's accounts every year, and a report goes to Parliament.

PART III

Super-Important Computers

Sections 7 – 8



Some computers are so important that if they break, the whole country feels it!

The country's heart, lungs and brain



Extra-strong safety rules (Section 7)

-  Locked and safe from the start
-  Logs: a record of who did what
-  Backup copies of important data
-  A plan to recover after a disaster
-  Respect for people's privacy



Section 8: Safety inspections

The Cyber Emergency Centre can check these systems at any time.

PART IV

Cyber Detectives

Sections 9 – 20

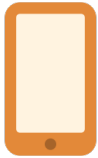


Online crimes leave clues. But detectives must follow fair rules too!

How cyber detectives collect clues fairly

1

S.9



Clues hide in devices

Messages, photos and files can all be evidence.

2

S.10



Ask a judge first

A High Court judge must give permission: a warrant.

3

S.10



Search & copy

Only what the warrant allows.

4

S.11



Write a receipt

List everything taken, with the date and time.

5

S.9



Proof in court

Properly kept screenshots and files can prove a crime.



Rules for detectives too!

Officers who misuse these powers commit a crime (1 – 5 years in prison).



Your privacy matters.

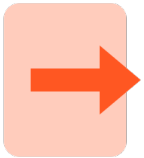
Data taken can only be used for the reason it was taken.

Special detective tools, only with a judge's YES



A High Court judge must agree first. Companies can challenge the orders in court, and other people's privacy must be protected.

S.12



Hand it over

A judge can order a person or company to hand over specific information.

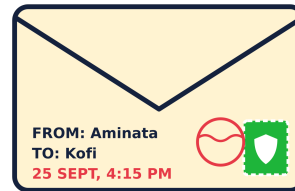
S.13



Don't delete that!

Clues must be saved, not deleted, for up to 30 days.

S.14



Watch the envelope

Record who contacts whom and when, live, for up to 30 days.

S.15



Read the letter

Only for serious crimes, and only 30 days at a time.

S.16



Obeying is safe

Companies that obey the law aren't punished for it.

No hiding, and no keeping the prize



No hiding behind a screen

S.17

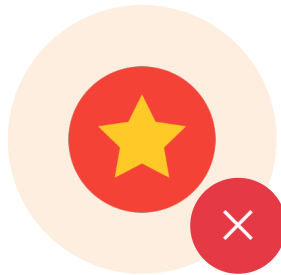
Sierra Leone's courts can judge cybercrimes that happen here, hurt people here, or are done by Sierra Leoneans anywhere in the world.



The chief lawyer leads

S.18

Cases go to court under the Attorney-General, the Government's chief lawyer.



Cheaters lose the prize

S.19

Money, property and devices from the crime can be taken away. The passport is kept until the sentence is done.



Pay the victim back

S.20

The court can order the criminal to give back what they took, or pay its value.

PART V

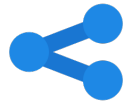
Teaming Up With the World

Sections 21 – 32



The internet has no borders, so countries team up to catch cybercriminals!

Sierra Leone teams up with the world



Share a tip

S.21

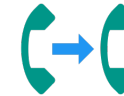
Sierra Leone can warn another country about a crime, even before being asked.



Keep secrets safe

S.25

Shared information stays confidential.



Ask for help, give help

S.23

Sierra Leone can ask for help, and can agree, refuse or delay when others ask.



Teamwork powers

S.22

Work with other countries and INTERPOL, the world's police network.



Face trial there, or here

S.24

A suspect may be sent abroad for trial. If not, Sierra Leone must try them at home.



Led by the Attorney-General

Fast help across borders, day and night

S.32



24/7

The cyber hotline never sleeps

Sierra Leone keeps a contact point open 24 hours a day, 7 days a week, to help other countries fast.



S.26

Freeze the data

Another country can ask Sierra Leone to save data for at least 90 days.



S.27

Follow the trail

If a message passed through another country, Sierra Leone helps trace its path.



S.28, 30, 31

Search, watch, read

Sierra Leone can help other countries search data or watch messages, with a warrant.



S.29

Noticeboard vs locker

Anyone may look at public information online. Private data needs permission.

PART VI

The Online Rules

Things you must never do · Sections 33 – 57



This is the biggest part of the law. Let's learn the online rules!

An open door is not an invitation



Breaking in

S.33

Getting into someone's phone, computer or account without permission is a crime. So is going further than you were allowed.

Your friend lets you see ONE photo, and you read all their messages? Not allowed!

 2 – 5 years in prison



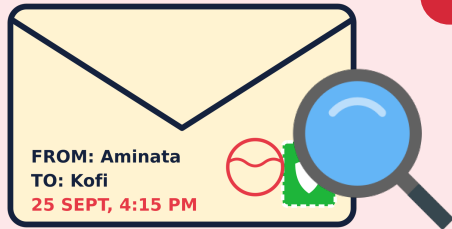
Breaking into super-important computers (banks, power, water) is also a crime: 2 – 5 years.

S.34



Never log in to someone else's account, even if they forgot to log out!

No snooping, no breaking



S.35

Secret listening

Secretly catching private messages as they travel is a crime.

Like opening someone's letters while the postman is carrying them.

 2 – 5 years in prison



S.36

Messing with data

Deleting, damaging or locking someone's files is a crime. Ransomware does this.

Like tearing pages out of someone's exercise book.

 2 – 5 years in prison



S.37

Breaking the system

Crashing websites, spreading viruses, or stopping a network from working is a crime.

Like putting sand in a bus engine so nobody can ride.

 2 – 5 years in prison

Hacking tools and passwords



S.38

Tools to HURT

Making, selling or keeping hacking tools or stolen passwords to commit crimes.

 5 – 10 years!



Skills to PROTECT

Training, testing and protecting systems, with permission, is allowed. That's what ethical hackers do!

ALLOWED



A locksmith learns to open locks to HELP people, not to break into houses. Sierra Leone needs future cyber defenders like you!

S.39



Your password is like a toothbrush

Never share it, not even with your best friend. Giving away someone else's password to cheat or harm them is a crime.

 1 – 3 years in prison

Faking it online is a crime

REPORT CARD

English **B**

Maths ~~**D**~~ **A**

Science **C**

FAKE!



Faking digital documents

S.40

Changing digital information so fake things look real, like certificates, receipts or results.

Changing a D to an A on your report card is not a joke. It is forgery!

 **1 – 5 years in prison**



Computer fraud

S.41

Using a computer to trick someone out of their money or property.

Like a fake online shop that takes your money and sends nothing.

 **2 – 5 years in prison**

Pretending to be someone else



Spot the red flags



"It's URGENT!"

Scammers rush you so you don't think.



Asks for money

By mobile money, right now.



"My new number"

A story to explain why it looks different.



The law: using someone's password, signature or personal details, or pretending to be another person to cheat, is a crime (S.42: 3 – 7 years). Faking an electronic signature is too (S.43: 3 – 5 years).

What to do

1



STOP. Don't send anything.

2



CALL them on the number you already know.

3



TELL a trusted adult.

Be kind online: no cyberbullying



Messaging again and again
to scare or upset someone



Sending cruel or threatening messages
or rude, indecent things



Spreading lies on purpose
to hurt or frighten people



All of these: 2 – 5 years in prison

If someone bullies you online:

1



Don't reply

2



Take a screenshot

3



Block them

4



Tell a trusted adult

Respect names and creative work

Stealing names online

S.45

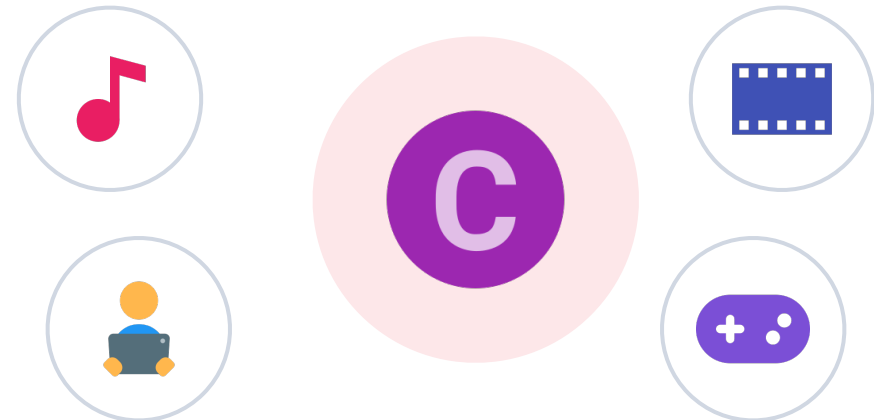


Grabbing a name or website address that belongs to someone else is not allowed. The real owner can go to court, and the court can order it handed back.

Like sitting in someone's reserved seat and refusing to move unless they pay you.

Copying other people's work

S.46



Illegally copying or sharing music, films, books, software or games is a crime. Creators work hard: use legal apps and websites.

 2 – 5 years in prison

Your pictures, your privacy



The law protects you

It is a serious crime to share private pictures of children, or to use the internet to befriend a child in order to harm them (S.47). Sharing anyone's private pictures, videos or voice notes without permission, or threatening to, is also a crime (S.48).

Warning signs



Asks for private pictures



Says "keep it secret from your family"



Sends things that make you uncomfortable



Wants to meet you in person



STOP



DON'T REPLY



**TELL A TRUSTED
ADULT**

It is NEVER your fault. The law punishes the person who does this: 5 – 10 years in prison.

More online rules



Helping is a crime too

S.49

Trying, helping or preparing a cybercrime gets the same punishment as doing it. The lookout is in trouble too!

 Same as the crime

Cyber cafés must register

S.50

Using a cyber café for online fraud is a crime. The owner is only in trouble if they helped.

 3 – 5 years in prison

Cyber terrorism

S.51

Using computers or networks for terrorist acts is one of the most serious crimes in the whole law.

 10 – 20 years in prison

No hate online

S.52

Spreading hate or threats against people because of their race, ethnic group, nationality or religion is a crime.

 1 – 3 years in prison

Everyone has a job in keeping the internet safe

S.53



See smoke? Report it!

Organisations must report cyber attacks within 7 days.

S.54



No cheating customers

Companies that misuse customers' security codes can be punished, even shut down.

S.55



Hand back the keys

When you leave a job, give back all passwords and access.

S.56



Bosses keep watch

Leaders who don't supervise properly can be punished.

S.57

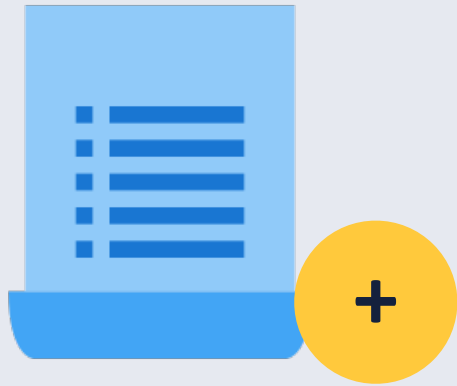


Children are treated as children

Child protection laws apply, but actions still have real consequences.

Sections 53 – 56: 1 – 3 years in prison for breaking these rules

The final section: adding details later



Big rules + small details

The Minister can make extra, more detailed rules called **Regulations** to help the law work in practice.



Think of it like...

The school rulebook sets the big rules. The head teacher can add the details, like which gate opens at what time.



Well done, Cyber Explorer! You've travelled through all 58 sections of the law.



The Cyber Explorer's 10 Golden Rules

1



Keep your password secret

S.39

2



An open door isn't an invitation

S.33

3



Don't take the phishing bait

S.42

4



Check before you trust: call them

S.42

5



Be kind online

S.44

6



Think before you forward

S.44

7



Private pictures stay private

S.47 – 48

8



Respect everyone

S.52

9



Respect creators

S.46

10



Tell a trusted adult

Always!

Crime, or not a crime?

1

Your friend forgot to log out of their account on your phone. You read all their messages.

CRIME

NOT A CRIME

2

In ICT club, your teacher shows you how to test the school system for weak spots, with permission.

CRIME

NOT A CRIME

3

Someone forwards a made-up, mean story about a classmate to frighten them.

CRIME

NOT A CRIME

4

You get a scary message from a stranger and show it to your parent.

CRIME

NOT A CRIME

Answers: how did you do?

1

Your friend forgot to log out of their account on your phone. You read all their messages.

**CRIME**

Section 33: using an account without permission is breaking in.

2

In ICT club, your teacher shows you how to test the school system for weak spots, with permission.

**NOT A CRIME**

Section 38: testing and protecting, with permission, is allowed.

3

Someone forwards a made-up, mean story about a classmate to frighten them.

**CRIME**

Section 44: false messages to hurt or scare someone are a crime.

4

You get a scary message from a stranger and show it to your parent.

**NOT A CRIME**

That's exactly the right thing to do. Well done!

Use your cyber powers for good!

Sierra Leone needs future cyber defenders, and you could be one of them.

Securing Sierra Leone's Digital Future: A National Call to Cyber Resilience
Partnership. Protection. Progress.



Cybersecurity Unit
Parliament of Sierra Leone

This guide simplifies the Cyber Security and Crime Act, 2021 for learning. It is not legal advice; the official Act is the authority.